

Municipal Policy Knowledge and the Limits of Local Democratic Accountability

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1. Motivation

- Theories of democratic accountability require voters to observe government performance and reward or punish incumbents accordingly
- Smaller scale and day-to-day impact of policy should make local governments easy to monitor, but some argue structural features of local politics create a “low-information” environment instead

2. Research Questions

- Do residents’ beliefs about which policies their city governments have enacted align with reality?
- Does partisan thinking about city policy help or hurt that alignment?
- What are the consequences of resident knowledge (or lack thereof) about city policy for local democratic accountability?

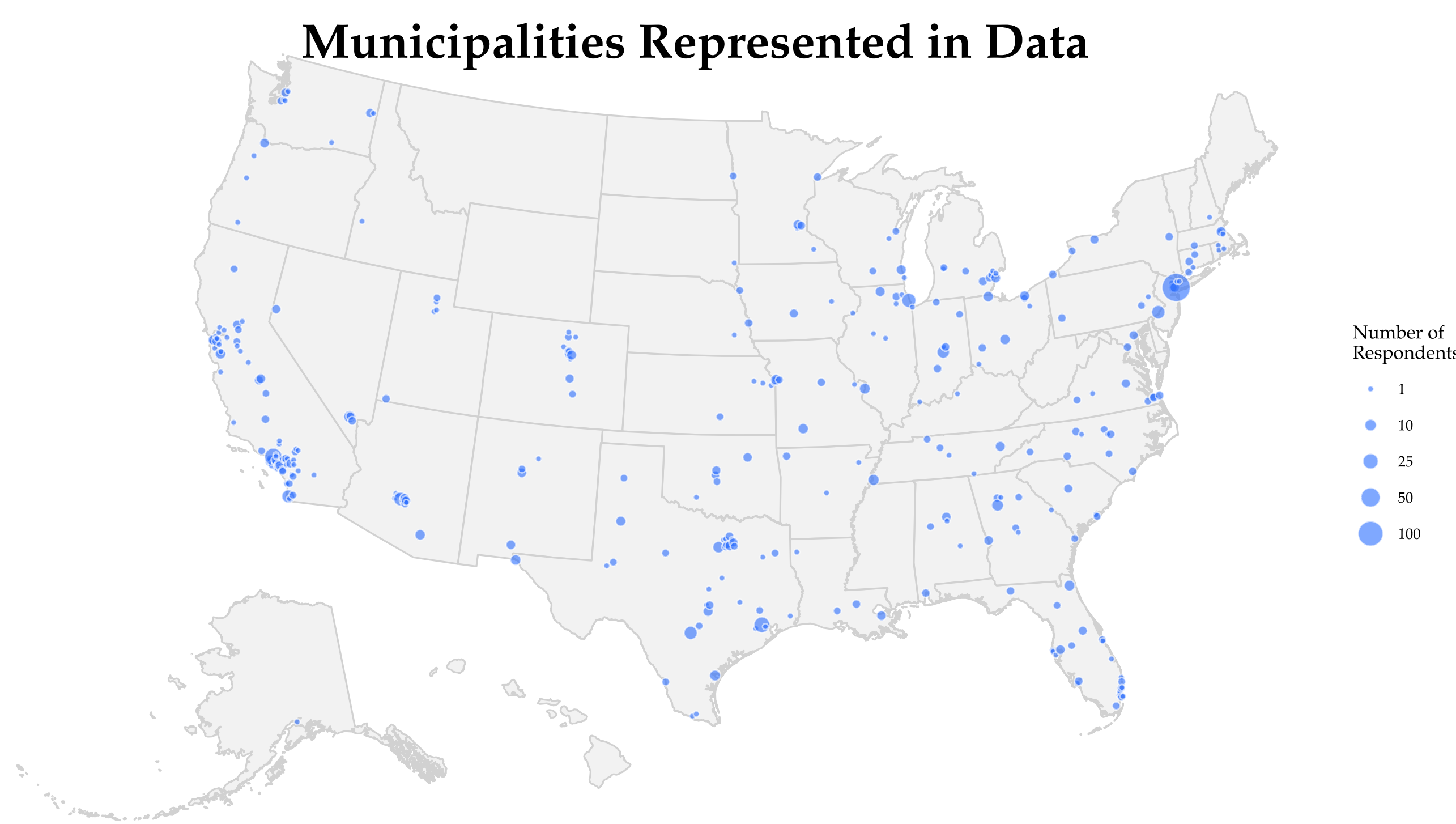
3. Data

Municipal Policy Dataset

- Accounting of standing policy concerning *20 issue areas* in all *484 U.S. municipalities* with a population $\geq 75,000$
 - Policies span major functional domains of local governments, including land use, housing/homelessness, public safety, environmental sustainability, transportation, and resident inclusivity
- Compiled via AI-assisted web search with detailed citation information, audited and corrected by trained human researchers

Original Survey

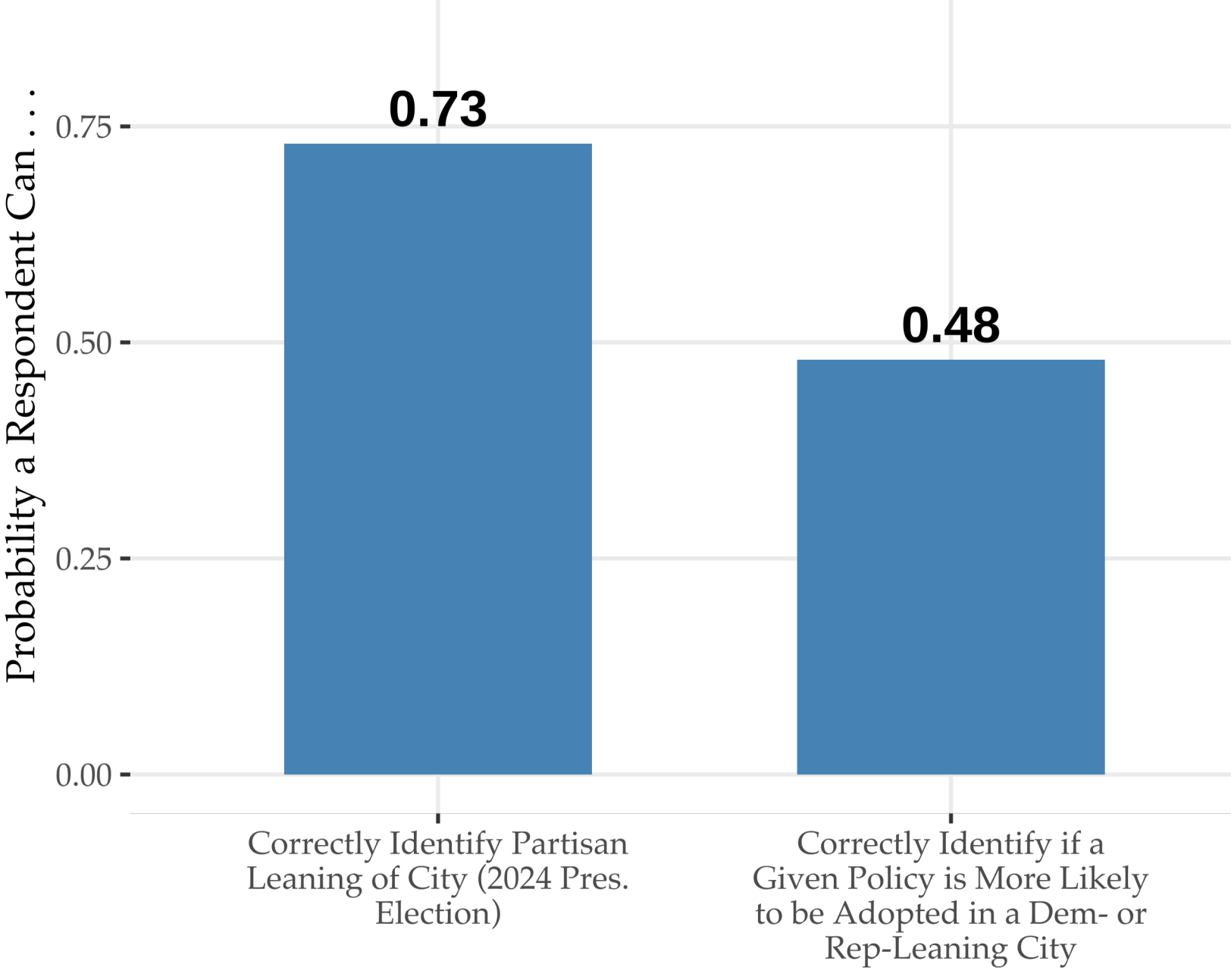
- 1,028 U.S. adults* sampled from those living in the 484 cities covered by the policy dataset, fielded April 23-28, 2026 (Verasight)
- For each of the 20 policies, respondents indicated whether they believed each had been enacted by their own city, their own preference on the policy, and whether they think the policy is more likely to be enacted in a Democratic- or Republican-leaning city



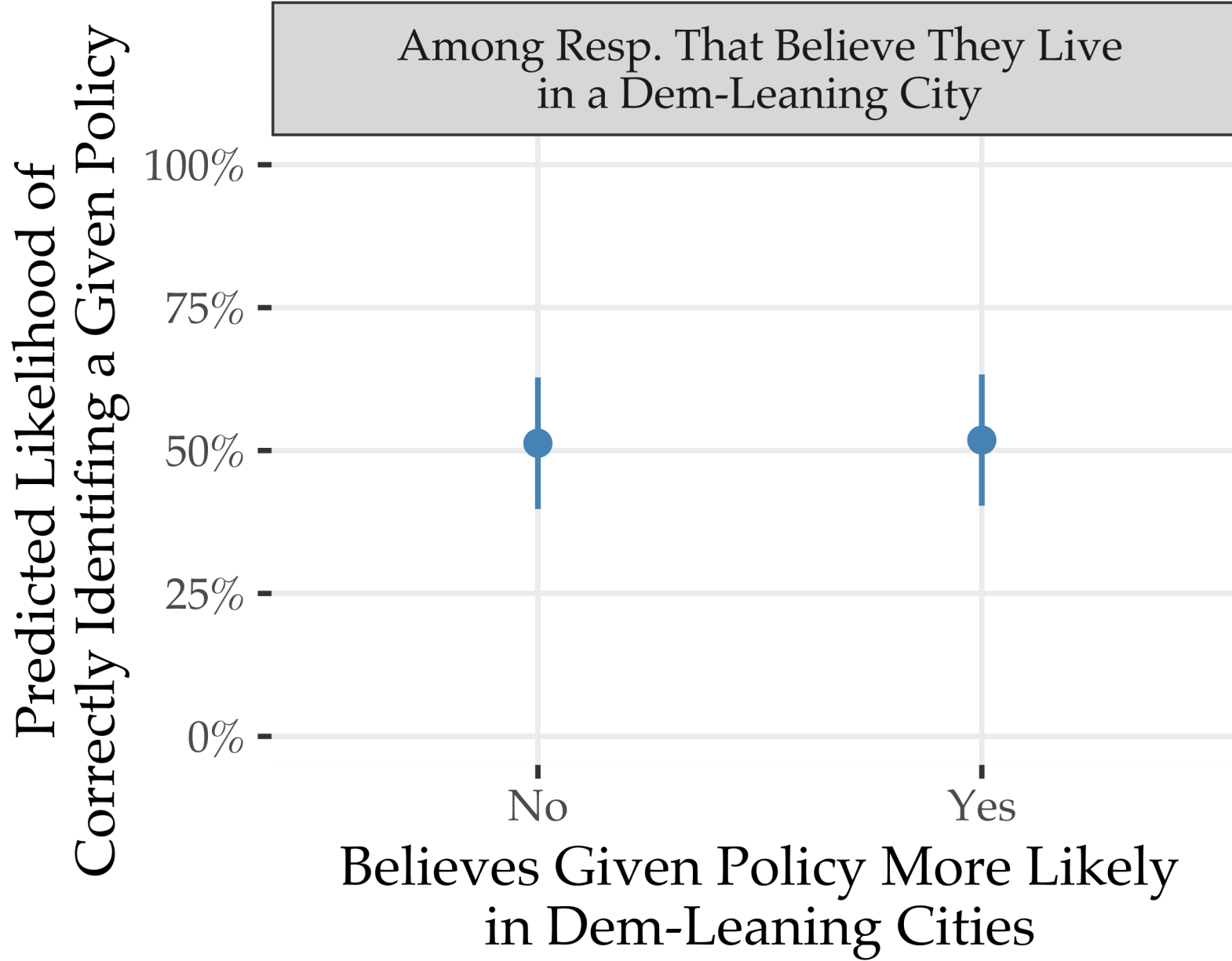
4. Knowledge of Local Policy Only Slightly Better Than a Coin Flip

- Residents are accurate in their perceptions of which policies their city has enacted *57.8% of the time* on average, or about *11.6 out of 20 policies*
- The most common form of error is respondents’ assuming their city has passed a policy it has not
- Knowledge is similar across groups, there is no informed “type” of resident

Perceptions of City & Policy Partisanship



Interaction Effect of Aligned Partisan Beliefs



6. Perceptions of Policy Congruence, Not Actual Policy Congruence Predict Incumbent Evaluations

- Residents reward city governments for *policy records they imagine*, not that actually exist
- Accurate and inaccurate perceptions of congruence impact approval of city governments at almost identical magnitudes
- Perceived policy congruence remains a strong, statistically significant predictor even when accounting for retrospective evaluations of city conditions and shared partisanship

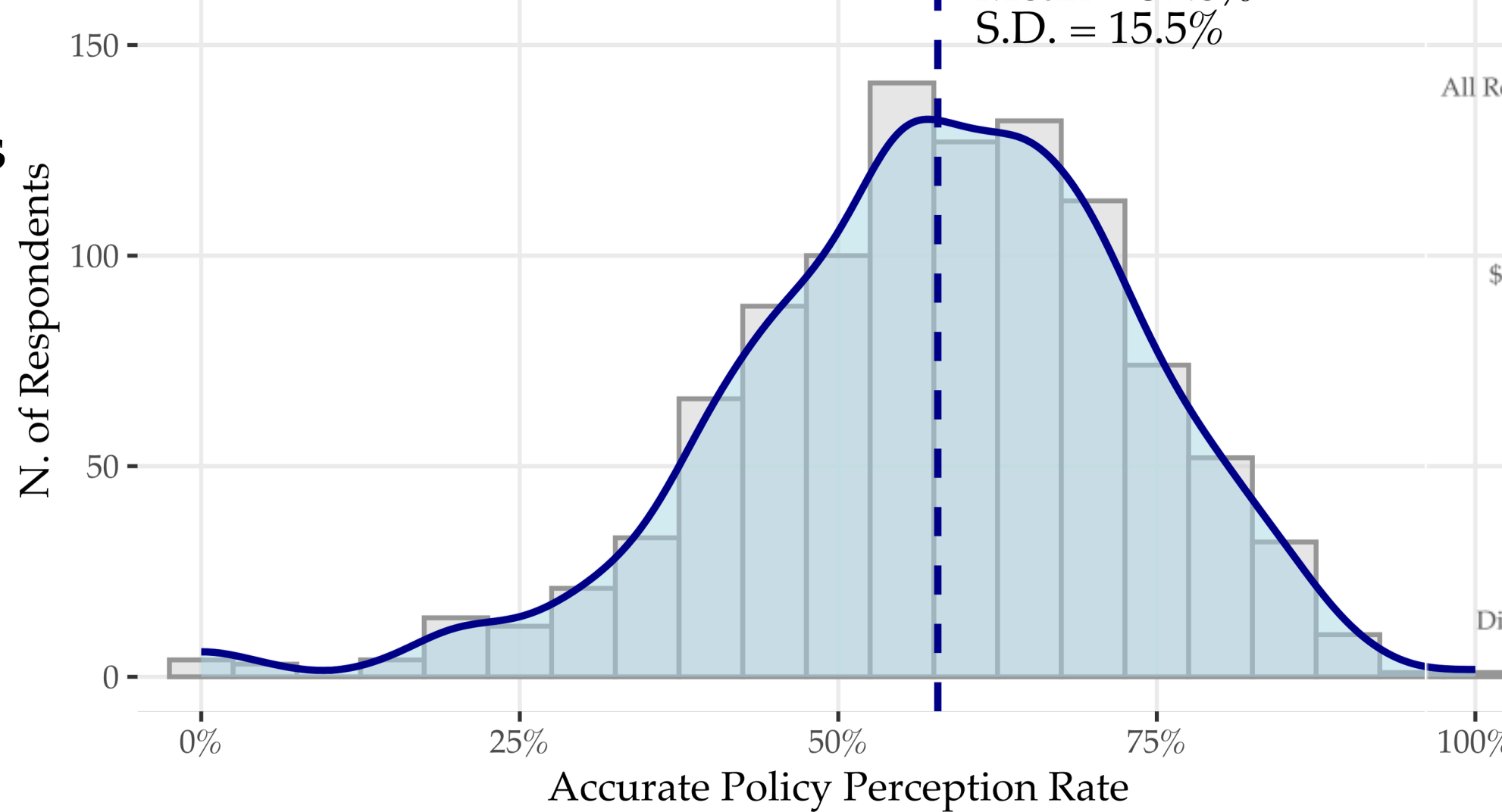
7. Robustness

- Cross-sectional design cannot adjudicate whether misperceptions drive approval or approval drives misperceptions, but either account demonstrates a failure in accountability
- Findings are stable across sensitivity checks that drop individual or random groups of policies and simulate a reduction in respondents’ tendency to over-assume policy adoption

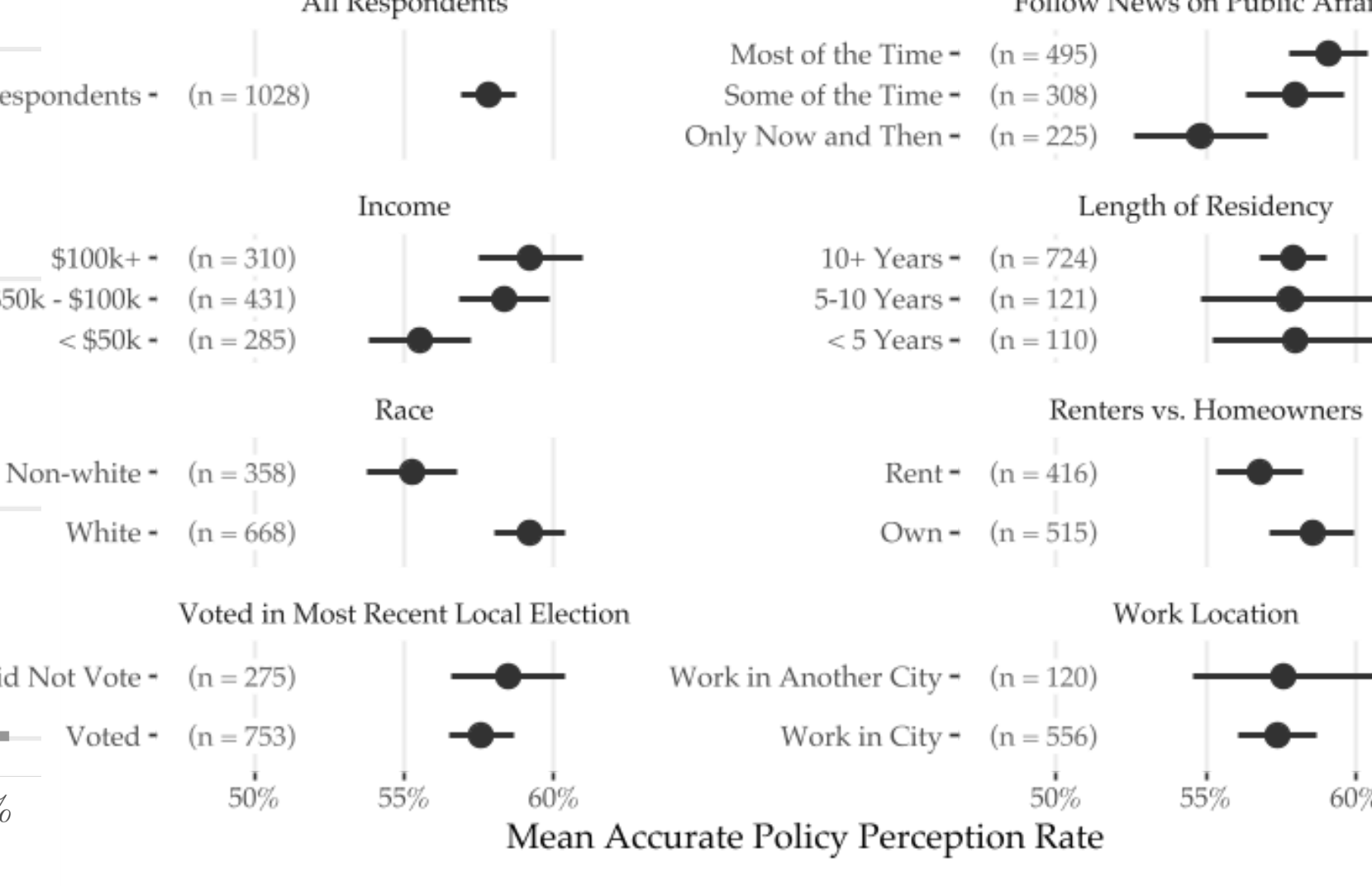
8. Implications

- Aggregate responsiveness of city policy to public opinion found in prior work is unlikely to be driven by individual voters monitoring and rewarding actual policy records
- Nationalized partisan reasoning is a poorly calibrated shortcut that does not guarantee voters arrive at accurate conclusions about local policy
- Reframes accountability critiques: voters are evaluating based on records that are partly imagined

Distribution of “Knowledge” of Local Policy



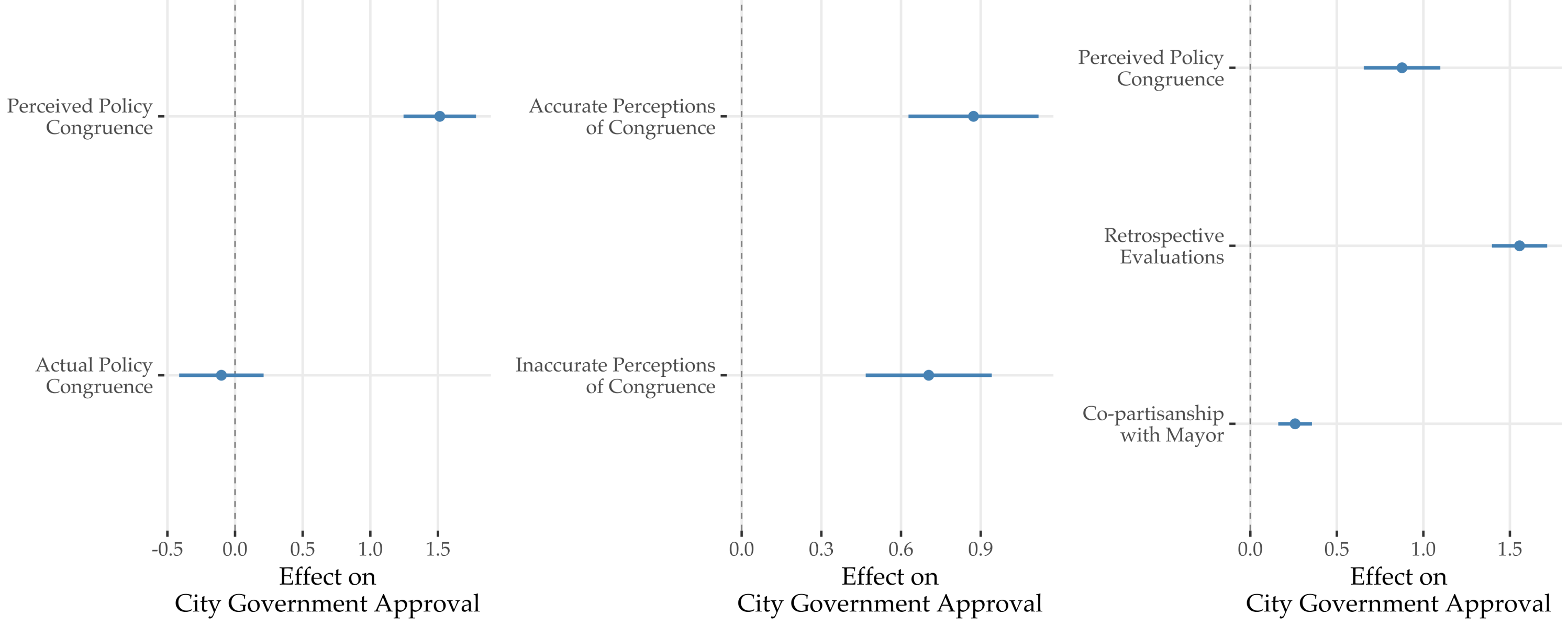
Knowledge is Strikingly Uniform Across Demographic Groups



5. Partisan Reasoning Does Not Improve Policy Knowledge

- 73% of respondents* accurately identify whether their city’s electorate supported Dem. or Rep. candidate for president in 2024
- But, *less than half* can correctly identify whether a given policy is more likely to be enacted in a Dem.- or Rep.-leaning city
- Alignment between a respondent’s beliefs about the partisan nature of their city and a given policy does not increase their accuracy

The Effects of Policy Congruence (Perceived and Actual) on City Government Approval



9. Read the Paper!

